

Chapter 18: When He Stops Asking

The next morning, Jenny expected silence.

She got the opposite.

Austin was already there when she arrived.

Table seven.

Same place.

Same posture.

But this time, he didn't wait for her to come to him.

He stood up the moment she entered.

Jenny stopped halfway.

"...You're early."

"I didn't sleep."

That made her pause.

"Why?"

Austin looked at her.

Not tired in the usual way.

Something more restless.

"I kept thinking."

Jenny sighed.

"About what now?"

He didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"About you."

That should have annoyed her.

It didn't land that way anymore.

It just... stayed.

Jenny walked closer anyway.

"What about me?"

Austin studied her face for a moment.

Like he was deciding how much truth to give.

Then he said quietly,

"I keep trying to make sense of what happens when I'm here."

Jenny crossed her arms.

"And?"

"I can't reduce it to logic."

That made her frown.

"You're a trader. That's all you do."

A faint pause.

"I know."

"So what's the problem?"

Austin stepped slightly closer.

Not enough to crowd her.

But enough that she felt it.

"I'm used to understanding everything I commit to," he said.

Jenny tilted her head.

"And me?"

A beat.

"You don't fit that."

That answer should have felt insulting.

It didn't.

It felt honest.

Too honest.

Jenny looked away first.

Of course she did.

Behind them, the restaurant slowly woke.

But around them...

It felt like a separate space.

Smaller.

Heavier.

Jenny finally said,

"You're overthinking it."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"I stopped asking myself if I should come."

That made her freeze.

Jenny looked back at him.

"...What does that mean?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"It means I just come."

Silence.

Jenny's chest tightened.

"That's not normal."

"I know."

"That's not healthy."

"I know."

"That's not—"

"I still do it."

That cut her off completely.

Because there was no argument left in that sentence.

Just fact.

Jenny exhaled slowly.

"You can't just decide things like that."

"I already did."

She shook her head.

"This is going to get you into trouble."

Austin's expression softened slightly.

"Maybe I want it to."

That made her go still.

"...Don't say that."

"Why?"

"Because you don't know what you're asking for."

"I think I do."

Jenny laughed once.

Short.

Unbelieving.

"No. You don't."

Austin didn't respond immediately.

Then he said something quieter.

"Then teach me."

That stopped her.

Really stopped her.

Jenny stared at him.

"Teach you what?"

"How to understand this."

A pause.

"Whatever this is."

The word *this* hung between them again.

Not defined.

Not safe.

Jenny shook her head slowly.

"This is a bad idea."

"I know."

"You keep saying that."

"Because it's true."

A beat.

Then softer—

“But I’m still here.”

That silence after was heavier than anything before.

Jenny felt something shift again.

Not falling.

Not rising.

Something in between.

She stepped back slightly.

“Go sit down,” she said quietly.

Austin didn’t move.

Jenny frowned.

“I said sit.”

A pause.

Then—

“Are you telling me what to do now?”

“Yes.”

That almost made him smile.

Almost.

He sat.

Slowly.

Like he was accepting something he didn’t fully understand yet.

Jenny exhaled.

"You're impossible."

"You said that before."

"I still mean it."

A faint pause.

Then—

"Good."

Jenny blinked.

"Good?"

Austin looked at her.

For once, completely direct.

"Because I don't want this to be easy."

That sentence lingered.

Heavy.

Real.

Jenny didn't respond.

She turned away quickly.

Too quickly.

But this time...

She didn't feel like she was escaping him.

She felt like she was stepping into something she couldn't pretend wasn't happening anymore.

And behind her, Austin stayed seated.

Not waiting.

Not chasing.

Just there.

Like he had finally stopped asking permission to exist in her life.